

Horror Cinema

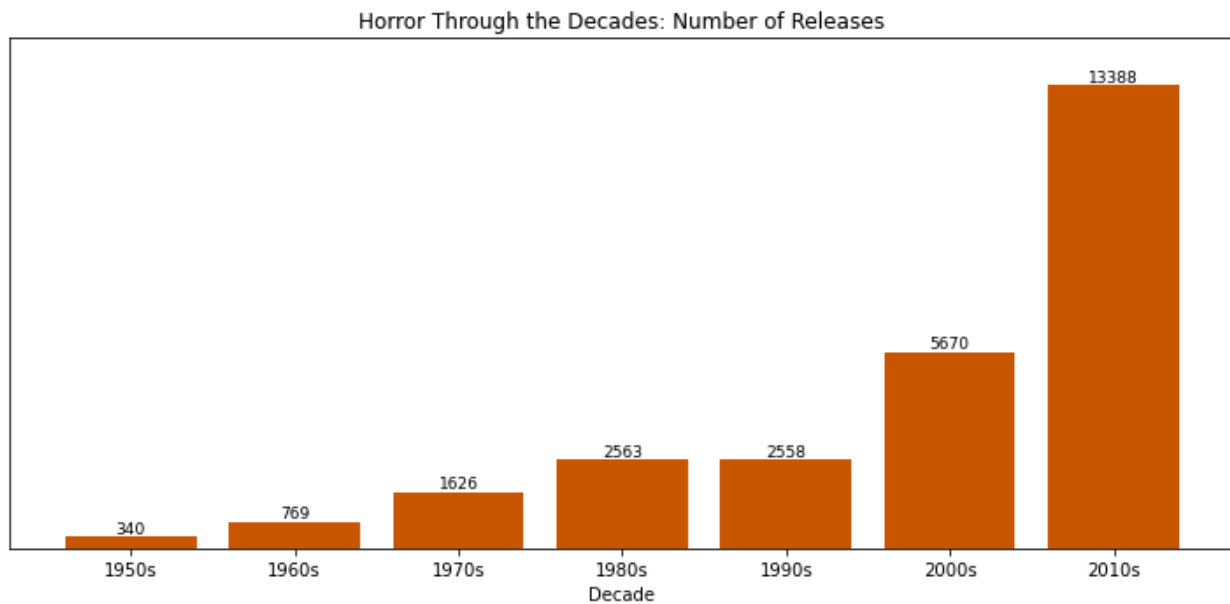
A data-driven look at horror trends over the decades

Kyle S. Mellors

Regis University (MSDS 670: Data Visualization)

I love horror. I love to read horror novels, watch horror films and television series, and listen to horror-related podcasts. I am also writing horror stories in my free time. I am not alone. The “horror” genre is as much of a guilty pleasure for those who enjoy it as it is downright abominable to those who despise it. Horror has been around for centuries, with Mary Shelley’s novel, “Frankenstein”, released over 200 years ago and Murnau’s horror film “Nosferatu” released over 100 years ago. However, it wasn’t until the mid 20th century when the horror genre really became part of pop-culture, with horror titans such as George Romero, Wes Craven, John Carpenter, and Stephen King emerging. Whether you like horror or not, there is a very high likelihood you hear about it on a regular basis due to its imprint in cult media and pop culture. Additionally, and unlike most other genres, horror has the capability of leeching into all other major genres, and this is due to horror’s main focus on evoking emotion rather than falling in line with genre-specific barriers.

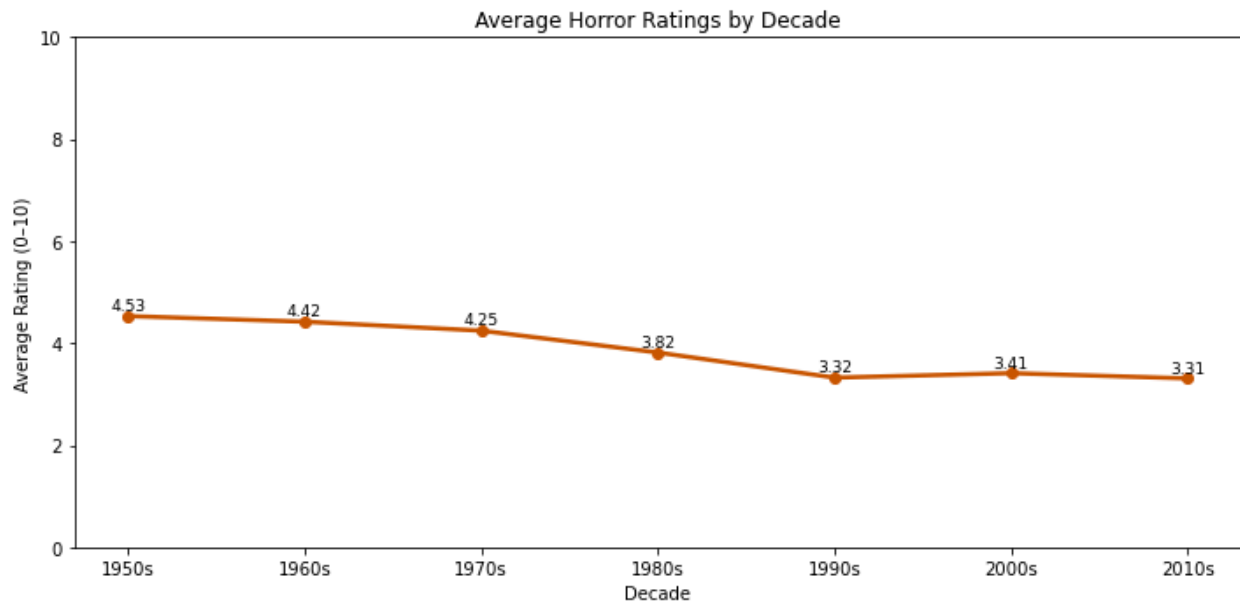
For this paper, I have analyzed the data and generated visualizations of a dataset (Kapadnis, 2023) with over 32,000 horror movies spanning from the 1950s to the 2020s (important note: due to the dataset ending in the middle of the 2020s, I dropped those movies, as they were creating artificially low numbers). The dataset contains 20 features, including but not limited to, title, language, overview, tagline, popularity, revenue, runtime, genres. For my visualizations, I focused on creating different types of visualizations, including a line graph, bar graph, scatterplot, and network graph. I also looked at different aspects of these movies, such as the number of horror films released each decade, average decade rating for horror movies, the top 15 most popular horror films, and the most popular genres paired with horror.

Data Visualization 1: Horror Movie Release each Decade (Bar Graph)

For this visualization, I was interested in seeing how many horror movies were released each decade. I was curious to see if there was, as I expected, exponential growth of horror movies being released. We can see from the visualization that, in fact, horror has grown substantially over the many decades, with phenomenal growth since the 2000s. It also looks like horror started really taking off starting in the 1970s where nearly 2,000 films were released (compared to the 1950s with under 400). There is a notable lack of growth in the 1990s, where less movies were created in the '90s than the '80s, the only period where growth did not happen for horror films. Additionally, as we will see in a later visualization, the '90s were also one of the worst performing years based on average horror film rating. Anecdotally, the '90s were seen as a time where original horror ideas and executions were not occurring and were not fulfilling the needs of the audience, since they could watch previous decade movies that were better liked and of higher quality. To add, the 2010s saw over 13,000 horror films released, and this is likely due

to the low barrier of entry (low budget) of producing and publishing horror films. This leads to many cheaply made, and generally unliked, films being released, also bringing down the decade averages.

Data Visualization 2: Average User Ratings over the Decades (Line Graph)

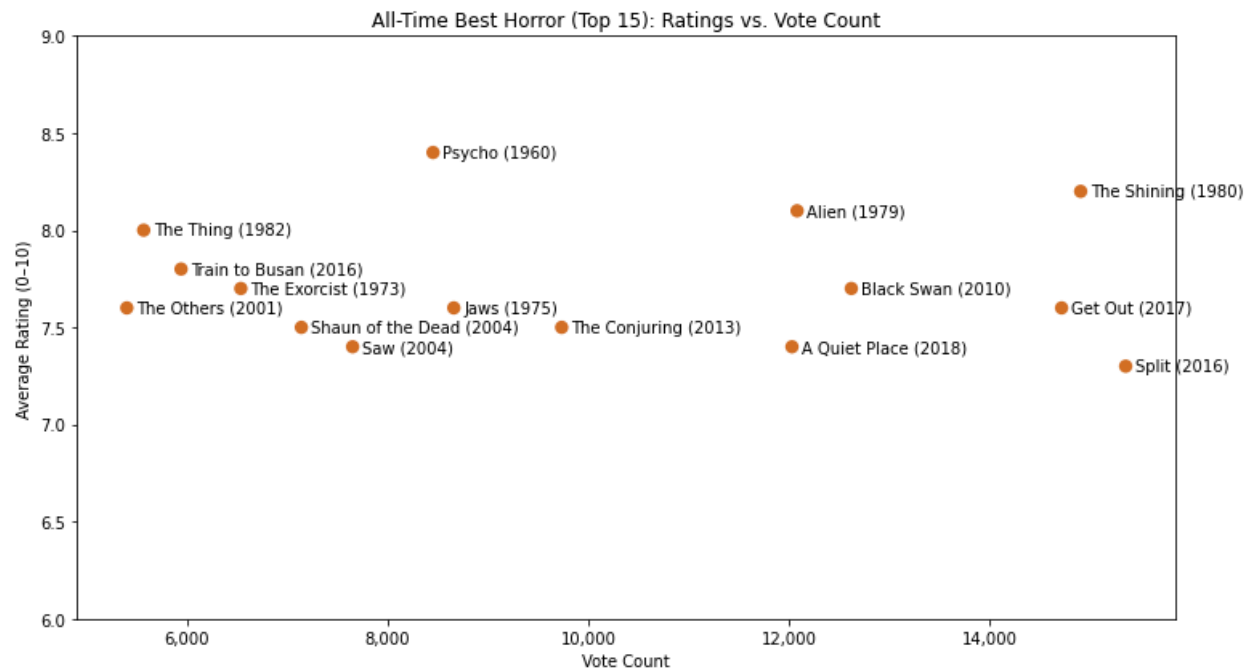


For this visualization, which I have referenced in the previous visualization discussion, I was interested in seeing how each decade fared against ratings of their horror movies.

Interestingly, and understandably, horror movies, on average, have low ratings. We can see that throughout every decade, the average rating, out of 10, was less than 5. This shows that regardless of the number of films released in a decade, horror has always been scrutinized and seen as a low-budget, low-effort genre. We also notice that as more decades go on - with more horror films produced - the lower the average rating becomes, and this means that horror suffers from a “quantity over quality” effect. However, as mentioned in earlier, horror was seeing a resurgence in the 2000s that is still going on into the 2020s, and the only time on this graph

where the average rating went up was from the 1990s to 2000s. The '90s had much fewer films, but they were so bad that even though the 2000s had over double the films released, they still were able to maintain a higher average rating.

Data Visualization 3: Best Horror Movies of all Time (Scatterplot)



Of course, what is the point of having a horror data set if you aren't going to look at the most popular movies from the data. So, I did. For this visualization, I used a scatterplot, and I limited the visualization to only show me the top 15 movies based on the number of votes (over 5,000) and the average rating. Instantly we see Alfred Hitchcock's "Psycho (1960)" has the highest rating of 8.4/10 with over 8,000 ratings. While this is the highest rating on the list, I would argue that Stanley Kubrick's "The Shining (1980)" is the most highly regarded film, as it has around an 8.2/10 with over 14,000 ratings. We can also see some very popular cult classics including "The Thing (1982)", "Jaws (1975)", "The Exorcist (1973)", and "Alien (1979)". Along

with those cult classics we can also see some films from the 21st century that have found their mainstay in pop culture, such as “Saw (2004)”, “Shaun of the Dead (2004)”, “Black Swan (2010)”, “Get Out (2017)”, among others. Notable, though, is that there is not a single film represented in the top 15 from the 1990s, the decade of the “horror slump”.

Data Visualization 4: Most Popular Genre Pairings with Horror (Network Graph)



For this visualization I was interested in looking at something a little different. One thing I mentioned earlier is that horror has the unique benefit of being intertwined with other genres, and so I decided to look at how the different genres co-existed with “horror”. Nearly all films are listed as being in more than one genre (Dramedy, Horror Comedy, Action Thriller, etc.) and so I was interested in what that looked like for horror. For this network graph I chose only the top 10 most recurring genres with horror (horror being number one). For this network graph, the size of

the bubble, the thickness of the edges (lines), and the proximity to the center “horror” bubble describe that genre's relationship to horror (and the other genres). For instance, “thriller” has the biggest bubble (outside of “horror”) , the closest proximity to “horror”, the thickest edge, and the most connections to the other top genres. This correlates directly to the fact that “thriller” is much more commonly paired with horror than any other genre. Additionally, “comedy”, “sci-fi” and “drama” are also commonly paired with horror. While this is the top 10 (or really, 9) most popular genres, “animation” is the least popular of the most popular genres paired with horror.

Conclusion

Horror is here to stay. At least that is what the data is showing. However, horror is an anomaly because of its high popularity, low average ratings, and its ability to seamlessly meld into other genres. Horror movies have seen a steady increase in popularity since the 1950s, where only 340 movies were released, to the 2010s, where over 13,000 horror movies were released. While the number of horror movies has increased, the average ratings have decreased over the decades. This is likely due to the low barrier of entry and numerous “horrorslop” films being produced and published. Interestingly, the 1990s saw a unique occurrence where horror became stagnant. The 1990s, unlike every other decade, did not see an increase in horror movies released from the previous decades. Additionally, the 1990s managed to maintain the lowest average user rating. The “horror slump” of the ‘90s was a real phenomenon. While I suspect that we will continue to see major increases in the number of horror films produced over the coming decades, I also believe that horror will continue to maintain its low barrier of entry and its low ratings. However, no matter what, I, along with many others, will continue to be lifelong horror fanatics.